Committee: Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

Topic: The Question of Promoting Financial Inclusion in Developing Nations through Central Bank Digital Currencies (CBDC)

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Introduction

In developing nations, especially where bank infrastructure is insufficient, it is challenging to access formal financial services, and many people remain excluded from the formal banking system because they do not have access to ID cards or minimum deposits required to open bank accounts. Currently, according to the World Bank data, approximately 1.4 billion adults remain 'Unbanked' across the globe. Since they can't access their local bank institutions, those underserved populations are more restrictedly relying on physical cash, which leaves their assets highly vulnerable to theft, fires, or predatory money lenders. Not only do these immediate inconveniences exist, but reliance on physical cash also creates stronger macroeconomic problems that transform financial exclusion into a significant challenge to economic resilience and development. First, this situation, where people rely more on physical cash, pushes small business owners and market merchants to suffer from physical security costs. Because they are storing massive amounts of paper bills every single day, they are continuously at risk of armed robbery, meaning they have to allocate a large portion of their income to security measures just to protect their daily earnings. Second, when an economic emergency hits the developing countries, the lack of a digital banking network makes the local currency lose its value much rapidly. In consequence, it leads to higher transaction costs or financially forcing citizens to carry large and heavy bags of paper money just to purchase and consume basic necessities. Third, paper cash causes a great deal of inefficiency in money transactions. Counting out physical cash slows down the productivity of starting small businesses, which could be such as purchasing agricultural land or transportation. Finally, using cash has no digital footprint, preventing individuals from building credit histories needed for formal loans while decreasing the transparency of state tax base

To address these digital-systemic vulnerabilities, Central Bank Digital Currency, a digital form of a country's sovereign currency being issued by its central bank, is a viable solution. Utilizing the Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) system, developing nations can promote financial inclusion, provide safety, and affordability and build a more stabilized economic environment. CBDC can partially relieve unnecessary and inconvenient financial costs, such as transaction fees as previously mentioned, and the government's inefficient financial aid disbursement. By enabling direct Government-to-Person (G2P) social safety net transfers without intermediaries, central banks ensure emergency relief funds reach disaster victims instantly and transparently, reducing corruption and leakages. However, to fully integrate CBDC into the international financial ecosystem, developing nations must overcome critical technical and structural obstacles. These obstacles include a severe digital divide, insufficient electrical grid stability, vulnerability to cyberattacks, and public distrust regarding state surveillance and privacy erosion. Successfully navigating these complex trade-offs while balancing domestic financial stability requires a fundamental responsibility for the international community and member states of ECOSOC.

Definition of Key Terms

Central Bank Digital Currencies (CBDCs)

Central Bank Digital Currency is a digital version of physical cash, which is issued and ensured by the central bank. In contrast to private cryptocurrencies like Bitcoin, which are at risk of plummeting in value, CBDC is the safest money with 100% guaranteed value unless the country goes bankrupt. How CBDC could be dependable for citizens can influence the developing nations extremely positively. Since people living in developing countries are much more likely to live in marginalized areas, they aren't capable of easily accessing financial services.

Also, CBDC can be conducive to stopping corruption by providing transparency and traceability in financial transactions. Considering that the central bank is supervising all of the digital footprints, it decreases the occurrence of corruption like embezzlement of public funds. However, has potential to be utilized for over-surveillance, affecting people's digital privacy much more vulnerable.

Currently, over 130 countries, representing 98% of global GDP, are developing the CBDC system, where 72 countries are already on the advanced stage. To give a few examples of already existing CBDC, there is China's e-CNY, India's digital Rupee and Nigeria's eNaira according to the Central Bank Digital Currency Tracker.

For the additional information, CBDC is also called 'Sovereign Digital Currency', because it is directly created and backed by a country's government or central bank, meaning it carries the full official power and money trust of that nation.

The Unbanked

The 'Unbanked' is a sociology term indicating individuals or groups who are not able to use standard banking services. They are not able to do that usually because of lack of physical bank branches, official bank ID cards, or enough money for minimum deposits in order to make bank accounts. Without a bank account, they will make their money vulnerable to theft and struggle at formal jobs which require direct deposit. The unbanked population is heavily concentrated in developing economies like Nigeria, Mexico, India which amplifies their characteristic negatively.

Since they don't have bank accounts to save or store savings, a single devastating emergency can push them into absolute poverty.

Financial Inclusion

Financial Inclusion means providing everyone, especially poor and vulnerable people, with safe, affordable and reliable financial services such as bank accounts or credit cards. Worldwide, there are over 1.4 billion people, which is approximately 24% adults, financially excluded, indicating it's an urgent emergency and should be addressed as quickly as it can be. Internationally, ways for financial inclusion varies depending on the circumstances of the country. For example, in the Republic of Albania, the most efficient way for financial inclusion is not the establishment of a number of mobile banking accounts by private banks but implementation of a low-cost digital payment system for small-business enterprises operated primarily by central banks. This is suitable for Albania's economic environment, because small-enterprises take up over 85% of the whole market and this system can simultaneously increase the usage of finance and credibility regarding the central banks. Countries should be capable of determining which strategies they have to choose for financial inclusion.

Leapfrogging

Leapfrogging in economics refers to the pattern or sequence of events regarding the development where less advanced economies, industries, dodge the intermediate traditional stages and directly move into stages where they adopt more efficient and modern technologies. Leapfrogging in regions can promote faster economic growth, since leapfrogging countries bring high-value systems skipping step-by-step process. However, since their infrastructures are not as high as their technological systems' level, people often fail to maintain and maximize to their full potential. China, for example, is attempting to overtake the United States by leapfrogging in the Biopharma field. China is repatriating overseas experts and invested heavily in the domestic professional Science Technology Engineering Math (STEM) system.

Retail

Retail in economic terms is a final step for the distribution chain, where goods and services are sold straight to the consumers for either personal or business purposes. In the CBDC system, retail can affect the fundamentals of how money works as it is designed to be used as a digital dollar, euro

or other currencies for the general public. Unlike wholesale, retail sells individual items to everyday consumers, making Business to Consumer relationships (B2C).

Legal Currency

Legal currency is not a real commodity like gold or silver, but a currency issued by a government that values the authority and credibility of the issuing government. For example, the most commonly accepted legal currency is the U.S dollar (USD), involving roughly 89% in global foreign exchange transactions. Legal currency is not always restricted to currencies like USD or Euro, but also can exist as a cryptocurrency form. In El Salvador, Bitcoin started to be used as the legal currency in 2021 September 7th, enacting the ‘Bitcoin Law’. However, they were revoked in 2025 January 29th due to the lack of usage in business, and received $1.4 billion financial support from the International Monetary Fund (IMF), remaining as an example of cryptocurrency being the Legal Currency.

Distributed Ledger Technology

Distributed Ledger Technology (DLT) is a digital system where transaction records are shared, verified, and stored in multiple computer network servers instead of a single central bank server, in order to eliminate data forgery and other traditional problems. When applied to CBDCs, DLT reduces infrastructure and accounting costs by removing middle-brokers, increases security against hacking, and automates payment processing. However, like CBDC, before full implementation, DLT should overcome several challenges such as demolishing technology barriers, securing user privacy, and establishing a framework to hold this system.

Interoperability

Interoperability in digital monetary systems refers to the technical capability that different systems, platforms and services are connected without any constraints and can share data and resources. High interoperability ensures domestic CBDC to smoothly run Blockchain technologies, making cross-border payments flow much more efficiently and rapidly.

Digital Literacy

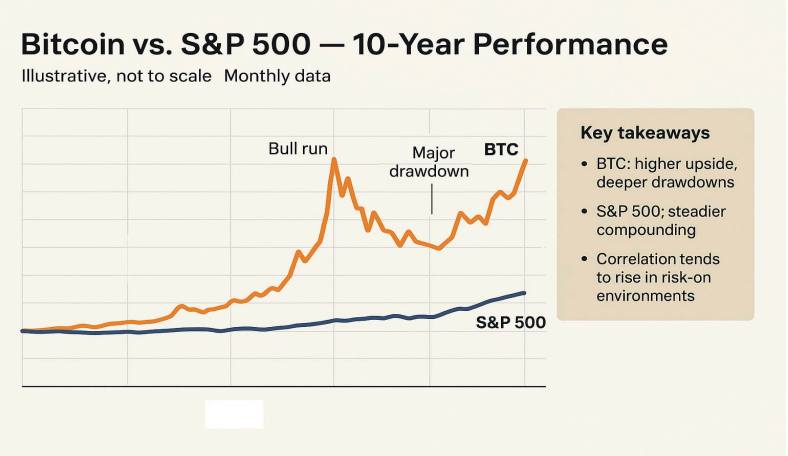
Digital Literacy refers to comprehensive competencies for critically evaluating, understanding, utilizing information in digital environments. Without sufficient digital literacy, vulnerable populations such as low-income earners, women, and the elderly risk being excluded from the economy, even if advanced financial infrastructure is established.

Background Information

Global Financial Crisis and the Rise of Bitcoin

Although there were few attempts to implement digital currencies in the 1980s, the actual rise of digital currency began with the collapse of the global financial system in 2008. During the 2008 Global Financial Crisis, major commercial banks and financial institutions failed due to risky investments, which triggered a massive economic recession worldwide. To prevent an entire economic collapse, central banks had to print trillions of dollars of new paper money in order to rescue these failing private institutions. The crisis weakened public trust in certain financial institutions. Furthermore, this crisis clearly showed the limitations of former banking systems. As a reaction to the 2008 financial crisis, an anonymous programmer named Satoshi Nakamoto published the Bitcoin white paper in 2008. Bitcoin was designed as the world's first decentralized digital currency, which was able to operate without any kind of touch of central bank or government. It made it possible to directly send money to people living far away. During Bitcoin's early stages, Tech entrepreneurs and businessmen, such as Jack Dorsey, expected Bitcoin to be a financial tool for people living in developing countries to bypass collapsed previous bank infrastructures and international remittance fees.

Bitcoin's innovative technology was highly evaluated. However, it ultimately had limitations for achieving financial inclusion to become a reliable financial source for unbanked people due to its extremely unstable price volatility and a lack of crypto consumer protection. Here, consumer protection refers to the measures and regulations existing to shield users from scams, financial loss, and hacks. Since Bitcoin is not backed by any government, its value entirely depends on market speculation, drastically following the market economic system, causing its price to skyrocket unpredictably within hours. Naturally, these factors pose significant financial risks and pressure for small businesses and low-income households to utilize it as their economic rebound. Additionally, the decentralized nature of Bitcoin is a double-edged sword, meaning that if a user loses their private key or becomes a victim of an online scam, their money is permanently gone with no legal authority to help them.



Comparison among fiat currency and Bitcoin (Research Gate, 2020) (The S&P 500 is a stock market index that tracks 500 of the largest public companies in the United States.)

The chart above from ResearchGate (2020) clearly shows this difference. While normal money, fiat money, and stable stock indexes like the S&P 500 show smooth and steady lines over time, Bitcoin's line goes up and down sharply like a wild roller coaster. This visual data proves that Bitcoin acts more like a risky market investment than a stable currency, making it unsafe for everyday use by unbanked people.

Evolution of Central Bank Digital Currency

While many people assume that Central Bank Digital Currency is a completely modern concept, in fact, the concept has been discussed for decades. The historical establishment of CBDC started by the bank of Finland in 1992, launching Avant smart cards, although the system eventually dropped in early 2000s. This Avant smart cards project is considered by economists to be one of the earliest prototypes of the CBDC.

The rapid expansion of mobile telecom networks in the late 2000s altered the trajectory of financial inclusion world wide, especially in developing countries. In 2007, Safaricom introduced M-Pesa in Kenya, demonstrating that people without bank accounts could completely bypass traditional offline branch infrastructure using only a basic mobile phone. M-Pesa operated as a private mobile money network based on commercial bank deposits. M-Pesa demonstrated that it is possible to go beyond the traditional banking system, but its private and lacking interoperability revealed

fundamental systemic flaws. Transaction fees, a lack of interoperability among operators as mentioned, and limited regulatory oversight regarding system liquidity risks during economic crises.

Since the risk of loss of currency-sovereignty has grown along with the limitations of private mobile money and the dangers imposed by decentralized cryptocurrencies and enterprise stable coins, central banks have turned to public digital bankings. In 2014, the central bank of Ecuador introduced the Sistema de Dinero Electrónico (SDE), being one of the earliest state-backed-up digital currency initiatives in the market. The main factor that differentiated SDE from previous transactions were the functions of it, which does not require a bank account for citizens to make payments via mobile codes. Although SDE was innovative, it wasn't enough and decommissioned in 2018 due to public's distrust of the government and low adoption rates among commercial banks.

For reference to the SDE and M-pesa, modern society is capable of constructing stable and long-term retail CBDCs for financial inclusion. In 2020, the Bank of the Bahamas introduced the Sand Dollar and unveiled the world's first fully operational national retail CBDC. By that implementation, the Bahamian government manifested how fully operational CBDC can maintain financial stability and resilience across the island region.

As the focus shifted to Asia, central banks began pursuing sovereign digital currencies primarily to safeguard their monetary independence and modernize payment networks. They recognized that relying solely on private payment platforms exposed the financial system to major risks, while physical cash was becoming increasingly expensive to print, store, and distribute. Recognizing this potential early on, the People's Bank of China launched official research on its own digital currency back in 2014, signaling a major global shift from early private mobile money services, like Kenya's M-Pesa, toward comprehensive, state leading digital financial systems across developing nations.

Current global situation

Today, many countries around the world are actively testing or launching their own CBDCs to modernize their national money systems for the purpose of efficient financial inclusion. But, still most of the developing nations are experiencing hard system backouts. Since they are experiencing frequent

power cuts, unstable internet networks, and weak technical infrastructure, running digital money systems without interruptions is extremely difficult. International financial institutions like the IMF and the BIS view these technical blackouts as a direct threat to public trust in government-backed money. They demonstrate that when a public payment system crashes, there are alternatives for users to choose, but when a national digital currency fails, citizens lose faith in their government's entire money system. Once public faith is collapsed, getting people to use digital money again becomes impossible. For this reason, global experts emphasize that cautioning central banks that ensure system stability must always come before speed.

Possible solutions

Financial Support and Cost Reduction

One of the biggest challenges for developing countries regarding the CBDC system is the cost of creating and maintaining it. Many governments don't have enough money or financial resources to build a safe economic network, develop software, and employ experts. Specifically, the normal cost of establishment of CBDC goes up to 300 million dollars, taking about 3~7 years, which represents a substantial burden for developing nations. Without external support, the CBDC system being implemented in developing countries, especially lower-income countries, is unlikely to be feasible.

To address this problem, international organizations like the United Nations, The World Bank, International Monetary Fund, or the regional establishment of international CBDC funds, are capable of being conducive to implementing CBDC, especially in financial support. Raised funds could be used in upgrading Distributed Ledger Technology (DLT) or centralized bank technologies and provide both technological and financial assistance to the developing countries who lack sufficient resources. Governments can also focus on urging Private-Public Partnerships (PPPs) to make Two-Tiered CBDC model, in which the central bank issues the digital currency and manages the wholesale while the private sector providers and commercial banks manage the retail and consumer accounts. This method can reduce the cost needed for the original method, making the establishment more efficient for them.

Digital Literacy and Public Education

Education is also one of the substantial factors for the whole topic. Even if CBDC becomes available in developing countries, many people, including the older generation, may not understand how to use digital wallets, protect their own personal information, or verify whether it's a straightforward deal or a scam. The limited digital literacy is one of the reasons why new financial technologies fail in developing countries. Governments should launch nationwide financial education campaigns before introducing CBDCs. Schools, governments, universities, and local communities should reinforce existing digital system education or provide cheaper, or even free training on how to safely utilize CBDC. Public awareness campaigns through television, radio, and social media can also increase understanding of CBDCs. Special education programs should focus on vulnerable groups, including women, elderly citizens, people with disabilities, and small business owners.

Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Resilience

Ensuring stable cybersecurity and network resilience is another vital challenge for developing states adopting digital financial systems. Developing nations often lack the advanced technological infrastructure required to defend central digital ledgers against cyberattacks, data breaches, ransomware campaigns, and insider threats. Furthermore, unreliable power supply networks, weak wifi coverage in remote regions, and natural disasters threaten the continuous operation of a digital economy.

To address these technological issues, it is necessary for developing countries to standardize domestic cybersecurity frameworks under the guidance of global organizations like International Telecommunication Union (ITU) or by cooperation with the Bank for International Settlements (BIS). Central banks should use high-level encryption and Distributed ledger technology (DLT).

Crossborder Payment Cooperation

Many developing countries heavily depend on remittances of citizens working overseas. However, international money transfers are often expensive, slow, and unavailable in remote regions. High transaction fees reduce the amount of money that families actually receive and limit economic development.

Countries should cooperate to create CBDC systems that are compatible with one another. International organizations, such as United Nations Trade and Development (UNCTAD), can help establish common technical standards and payment rules to improve interoperability between national CBDCs. Faster and cheaper cross-border payments would reduce remittance costs, support international trade, and strengthen economic cooperation between developing countries.

Implementing Laws and Regulations to Protect Banks and Privacy

The launch of a Central Bank Digital Currency requires a clear and effective legal framework. Before setting up digital systems, national governments must create official laws to define state money authority, protect traditional banks, safeguard personal privacy, and manage international money transfers without systemic errors or confusion.

First, national lawmakers must pass clear laws stating that digital money is a direct, risk-free responsibility of the central bank, fixed at an exact 1-to-1 value with paper cash. This legal definition separates state digital currency from risky private cryptocurrencies, like Bitcoin, and guarantees its legal role in paying off both personal and business debts. By passing mandatory legal tender laws, governments ensure that ordinary citizens and local shop owners can safely accept digital payments across the country without fear of refusal.

Furthermore, to protect the financial system from sudden panic, laws must set safety rules for commercial banks. To maintain financial stability, countries need to establish official holding limits on digital wallets to prevent sudden capital outflows from traditional banks. Moreover, governments must enforce a strict zero-interest rule, ensuring that citizens cannot earn interest on central bank digital currency and use it as a competing investment vehicle. These legal rules prevent people from moving all their savings out of commercial banks during economic panics, allowing every local bank to keep enough money to grant business loans.

Major Parties Involved

People's Republic of China

The People's Bank of China (PBoC) is at a highly advanced stage of implementing the digital Yuan, also known as the Electronic Chinese Yuan (e-CNY), making it the largest live central bank digital currency project in the world. According to official central bank data at the end of September 2025, the e-CNY ecosystem has processed over 14.2 trillion yuan, which is approximately $2 trillion USD, in cumulative transaction volume across more than 3.3 billion individual transactions. To test whether it can accommodate massive populations, China has registered over 225 million personal digital wallets on its official e-CNY application and expanded pilot programs across 26 major localities in 17 provinces, including financially advanced cities like Shanghai, Beijing, Shenzhen, and Suzhou. The government has successfully integrated e-CNY into everyday public life by using it for transportation fares, retail store checkouts and official civil servant salaries. Furthermore, China is extending its digital currency influence beyond domestic borders by co-leading Project mBridge, a multilateral cross-border payment network that has processed over $55 billion in international settlements.

The Commonwealth of the Bahamas

Established in October 2020, Bahamian Sand Dollar (BSD) is a central bank digital currency designed to promote financial inclusion. It earned significant credibility for its role in the aftermath of Hurricane Dorian, providing a digital alternative for the disrupted physical banking system. The Bahamian Sand Dollar (BSD) holds historical significance as the world's first fully deployed retail central bank digital currency released nationwide as legal tender.

Federal Republic of Nigeria

Launched in October 2021 by the Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN), the eNaira has a great significance since it's Africa's first central bank digital currency. Nigeria created the eNaira to increase financial inclusion for over 38 million unbanked adults and to reduce the high cost of handling physical paper money in a heavily cash-dependency. Despite its early launch, the eNaira serves as a vital case study for the global community regarding consumer adoption challenges. While

the central bank expanded the system to reach millions of digital wallets, actual transaction volume remained low, with retail transactions representing less than 1 percent of total national payments.

Republic of Ecuador

Ecuador managed to implement its own CBDC, known as ‘Sistema De Dinero Electrónico’, which operated from 2014 to 2018. The government introduced this system to reduce the heavy costs of using U.S. dollar bills and to help unbanked citizens send money easily using mobile phones. However, the project completely failed and was shut down in 2018. Citizens deeply distrusted the central bank, fearing the government would create digital money without real cash backing, while local commercial banks refused to support a system that completely excluded them. Because less than one percent of the population used it, Ecuador’s experiment proved that public trust and cooperation with private banks are essential for any digital currency to survive.

United States of America

The United States has prohibited the development of a U.S. digital dollar. They prioritized security, accuracy and privacy over speed, with President Trump signing an executive order banning federal agencies developing, issuing or protecting a CBDC. U.S financial regulators are concerned that state-issued digital currencies can provoke “bank disintermediation”, causing citizens to move their savings out of traditional commercial banks directly into the central banks. This abrupt shift can drastically reduce the funds available to private banks for loans to local businesses and homebuyers. However this legislation in America is temporary, as the congressional ban is set to expire at the end of 2030, leaving the door open for potential future administrations after 2031. Consequently, the United States is currently focusing on regulating the private banking system, instead of state-issued CBDC, managing the global dominance of the dollar.

International Monetary Fund (IMF)

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) is a major United Nations-affiliated institution created for the world's financial stability, preventing economic crises, and supporting nations suffering from national debt. To successfully manage the experiment of national digital currency in developing nations, the IMF established the CBDC virtual handbook, answering the most frequently asked questions on CBDC and guiding with chapters analyzing CBDC specifically. The IMF also built specialized economic simulation tools to demonstrate how launching a digital currency without safety

controls can trigger bank disintermediation which is a dangerous situation where panicked citizens move their savings out of local commercial banks directly into central bank digital accounts. Moving forward, the IMF can help developing governments build strict legal rules, such as zero-interest policies on digital wallets and strict daily holding caps, like capping individual digital wallets at $500, to stop commercial banks from losing their deposit base. Additionally, if a developing country suffers a sudden economic shock or currency collapse while testing a CBDC, the IMF can help with emergency policy loans and tailored economic assistance to protect the nation's financial stability.

Timeline Of Events

Date	Description of Event
The Avant Smart card, 1992 December	Finland's first CBDC "The Avant Smart Card" was established.
Launch of M-Pesa in Kenya, 2007 March	Kenya's largest telecommunications provider, Safaricom, introduces M-Pesa, a mobile phone based money transfer
Satoshi Nakamoto Releases Bitcoin Whitepaper, 2008 October	An anonymous developer publishes an electronic cash system 'Bitcoin', introducing decentralized blockchain technology in alternative to traditional banking systems.
Ecuador Launches Sistema de Dinero Electrónico, 2014 December	Central Bank of Ecuador launches 'Sistema de Dinero Electrónico', an early state-run mobile money scheme later discontinued due to low public trust.
Disruption by Hurricane Dorian, 2019 September	Hurricane Dorian devastates Bahamian banking infrastructure, highlighting the need for resilient digital payment solutions in island states.
People's Bank of China Launches Digital Yuan Trials, 2020 April	People's Bank of China launches large-scale pilot testing of the digital Yuan (e-CNY) across primary economic hubs.
Launch of the Bahamian Sand Dollar, 2020 October	The Central Bank of The Bahamas officially launches the Sand Dollar as the world's first fully deployed retail CBDC legal tender.
Eastern Caribbean Central Bank Launches DCash, 2021 March	Eastern Caribbean Central Bank launches DCash across member states to boost financial inclusion in island communities.
Launch of Nigeria's eNaira, 2021 October	The Central Bank of Nigeria launches Africa's first retail CBDC, the eNaira.

Bank of Jamaica Launches Jam-Dex, 2022 June	Bank of Jamaica introduces Jam-Dex, offering financial incentives to unbanked citizens who open digital wallets.
G20 Roadmap for Cross-Border Payments, 2023 October	G20 introduces updated roadmaps for cross border payment.
UN International Conference on Digital Financial Inclusion, 2025 October	UN on Digital Financial Inclusion highlights CBDCs as key mechanisms for accelerating Sustainable Development Goal 8.

UN Involvement, Resolutions, Treaties and Events

- UN General Assembly Resolution A/RES/70/1 (The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development), 25 September 2015,

United Nations General Assembly Resolution 70/1 emphasizes 5Ps, People, Planet, Prosperity, Peace, Partnership, where member states established 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) to cease poverty and transform global development. Financial inclusion serves as a critical enabling factor within this global blueprint, directly driving SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth), and SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities) by guaranteeing that vulnerable and marginalized populations gain equal access to economic resources and financial services. By deploying Central Bank Digital Currencies (CBDCs), developing nations can leapfrog traditional physical infrastructure barriers to deliver essential banking mechanisms directly to underserved citizens. This resolution provides an international policy framework that obligates member states to enhance their national payment ecosystems, reduce transaction costs for small businesses, and leverage state-backed digital financial assets to lift unbanked communities out of systemic economic isolation.

- General Assembly Resolution on financial inclusion for Sustainable Development, 15 December 2015 ,

- UN Secretary-General's Task Force on digital financing of the Sustainable Development Goals, 2020 August,

- UN Principles for Responsible Digital Payments, 2021 November,

- United Nations Secretary General's Special Advocate on Central Bank Digital Currencies

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